

ADCLOD Podcast Series with Social Impact Founders

Episode 8: Dr. Sunitha Krishnan, Prajwala

Neharika Vohra: Welcome to the ADCLOD podcast series with social impact founders, an initiative by the Ashank Desai Centre for Leadership and Organisational Development at IIM Ahmedabad, where we document and celebrate the leadership journeys of India's homegrown social entrepreneurs who have built impactful institutions from the ground up.

Neharika Vohra: In today's episode, we have the privilege of speaking with Dr Sunitha Krishnan, a fighter and one of India's most fearless anti-trafficking advocates. Sunitha co-founded Prajwala in Hyderabad in 1996, driven by a determination to ensure that no survivor faces abandonment. Over nearly three decades, Prajwala has assisted the police in removing more than 32,200 women, girls and children from places of exploitation to safe homes, and has provided rehabilitation services to them. Sunitha was awarded India's fourth-highest civilian honour, the Padma Shri, in 2016.

Neharika Vohra: Sunitha, it is a real pleasure and honour to be talking to you and learning from you. Welcome to our podcast.

Sunitha Krishnan: Thank you so much, Neharika, for all the very kind words. I'm extremely humbled to be here, and to connect with your students and your community is definitely time worth investing in.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you so much for your generosity and kindness. Let's get right into our conversation. Sunitha, could you give us a picture of what Prajwala looks like today — its scale, the range of survivors you serve, your centres, the nature of your team, and how the organisation is funded? Just help us understand what Prajwala is and how it operates.

Sunitha Krishnan: Prajwala today — and this is Prajwala of 2026 — is perhaps one of the largest anti-trafficking organisations working specifically on sex trafficking and sex crime. It's a niche organisation with its own particular character, because we don't do anything else. The entire organisation stands on five pillars: prevention, rescue, rehabilitation, reintegration, and advocacy. Before I go into each of them, I want to say that I look at Prajwala today as a very large laboratory of experiments testing how anti-trafficking work can be done. Every vertical I'll describe is really a different experiment in process — different tests being run on the ground to check what works and what doesn't.

Within the prevention vertical, at one end we run education programmes for the children of women in prostitution, providing them education as a means of preventing them from entering prostitution — what we call a second-generation prevention programme. We currently run around seven such centres. This was the organisation's very first intervention, going back to 1996, and it's been sustained for 30 years. Over that time we've kept around 17,000 children from being inducted into prostitution — essentially a 100% success programme.

The second experiment within prevention is engaging with communities we recognise as vulnerable — economically, by caste, socially, and geographically — the communities from which the highest numbers of people are trapped, lured, or fraudulently taken for exploitation. We engage with those communities, and I wouldn't use the word "aware" — I'd use "awaken." The goal of this community-based prevention programme is to equip the community with the skills to identify a potential victim, to watch for the red flags of a trafficker, and to know what to do if something like this happens — whom to report to, and how. It builds a whole community of vigilant people. From 1996 to now, we've engaged directly, one to one, with around 2 million people — children, ASHA workers, Anganwadi workers, teachers, village assistants, Panchayati Raj members, and others. Right now this runs mainly in Telangana, Andhra Pradesh and Odisha, though some components reach across the nation, and certain parts require direct, physical intervention. This programme is especially valuable because it feeds into our other work — it's the one that nurtures informers within the community, and that's where a great deal of the information for our rescue work comes from.

The third area within prevention is engaging with men and boys. We're working on the specific problem of sex crime and sexual exploitation, and the perpetrators and abusers are largely men. I wouldn't say women aren't involved — ironically, in sex trafficking, 78% of the crime involves women as perpetrators, procurers, transporters, and throughout the mafia structure. Women are the face of this crime, especially in sex trafficking, but women are also among the victims, alongside a large number of men and boys among survivors too — we have seen women abusers using boys, though that's a smaller number. So engaging with men and boys to help them review their own position in the problem — how they're contributing to it, how they're generating demand — matters. Something as seemingly small as consuming pornography can become a contributing factor in generating demand involving children. Today in our country we are seeing babies exploited — I have personally rescued three-year-old children who were sold into a brothel for direct prostitution. And if you look at the online space and what's called child sexually abusive material — child pornography, in plain terms — you'll find material involving children as young as six months old, both in terms of who is being bought and who is buying. So engaging with men to help them see their role in

perpetuating the problem, and then awakening them to become part of the solution, is the third strand of our prevention work.

The second vertical is rescue. It's the most dramatic part of our work, but I'd say it's actually the easiest part, because it's short-term. It requires a certain amount of criminal intelligence, some amount of grit, and a lot of devil-may-care attitude — that's about it. It happens in a jiffy. We do this work pan-India and in twelve other countries, so our reach is national and international. Wherever we get information, we move and carry out the rescue.

As I said, rescue is very short-term — the real work begins afterward, in rehabilitation, my third vertical. As of this morning, we have rescued 32,211 girls, women, and children out of sex trafficking. While rescue is the easy task, rehabilitation is the challenging part. We look at age-appropriate rehabilitation separately for children and for adults, and we take a trauma-informed approach, where every plan is unique to that person — one glove doesn't fit all. In this vertical we've experimented with different methods of trauma care, different psychosocial interventions, and different ways of delivering education — learning centres, bridge education toward mainstream schooling, and so on.

What genuinely works is livelihood and vocational training. One of the things I realised very early is that charity isn't sustainable — you can't stretch it indefinitely. Relying on corporate social responsibility, and guilt-tripping people into offering jobs, works for a little while but not in the long run. I'm a mental health professional by training, so I was looking for options that would be both psychologically and vocationally empowering. I was one of the first people in this country, and perhaps in the world, to experiment with non-conventional trades for women — bookbinding, welding, carpentry, fabrication, masonry. By and large, this has been very successful, in three ways. First, when a woman goes through a non-conventional trade, she breaks through patriarchal stereotypes and the glass ceiling. Second, psychologically, she starts to feel not just equal but superior — a woman who has been made to feel inferior, unworthy, not fit to return to society, reaches a point where she feels she is better than her own community, and better than us. When people visit our small industrial units, their eyes widen — "girls are doing this?" Or when these women take on-site jobs, installing grilles in a gated community, and the whole neighbourhood comes out to watch because nobody expected to see a woman doing carpentry — that's when healing happens, on multiple levels, moving from outright rejection to genuine awe. And beyond that, when they get poached by other workshops offering better pay, that's the ultimate signal — it means society wants them back.

We've experimented extensively along these lines. Today, in our rehabilitation programme, many of our children have become doctors, engineers, chartered accountants. They're in mass communications and other fields. Hundreds and thousands of our women work as carpenters and welders, and many have taken part in disaster relief — after the Andaman tsunami and floods in Kerala, our women played a prominent role in rebuilding homes.

Rehabilitation is a multi-pronged approach — psychological healing, vocational and educational empowerment, and civic support, ensuring survivors get their identity back: an Aadhaar card, a bank account, everything.

The fourth vertical is reintegration — coming back into society. This is a task in itself. As long as they're in our safe spaces, there's a certain safety. Coming out means confronting rejection and stigma head-on. A big part of our rehabilitation work is preparing women for that — for the fact that not everyone will accept them, and for them to prove themselves through their work regardless. Among the more than 32,000 we've rescued, a large number have chosen marriage as a path back to a normal life — we've supported around 9,500 marriages. I wouldn't claim to know the true number, though, because many survivors choose not to stay connected with us at all — they want to leave any association with Prajwala behind and build their own path, and there are many like that too.

Everything we learn from our experiments, failures, and successes feeds into our advocacy programme. Today, Prajwala is at the forefront of advocating for anti-trafficking laws and policy in several states. We've successfully shaped policy in Assam — the state government adopted the draft we provided. Telangana has adopted our policy, Andhra Pradesh has adopted our policy, Chhattisgarh is in the process of adopting it, and several other states are doing the same. Each of these policies has been tested for efficacy on the ground — these aren't academic papers, they come from what actually works. So if you ask me what Prajwala is today, I'd say it's a successful demonstration of anti-human-trafficking work. It sends a clear message to the world: that things people assumed were an inevitable reality — that sex trafficking, in the form of prostitution, is simply part of the human condition and can never change — aren't inevitable after all. We've created a dent in that thinking. Things can change. That's what Prajwala means today: an example of hope, and an example of possibility.

Neharika Vohra: Very nice. Thank you so much for the detailed answer, and also so peppered with hope and reality. This is a lot of work you're doing. Who is your team, how large is it, and what kind of people are part of it?

Sunitha Krishnan: I have a team of 200, and a significant portion of the team are survivors themselves — survivors of trafficking who have joined our mission. People often say that number sounds high, but it currently constitutes around 30% of

the team, and it's significant because their involvement isn't just as "survivors" — they're professionals contributing their skills to the anti-trafficking mission on equal footing. Of the 200, around 30% are survivors and the rest, 150 or so, are professional staff, mostly holding social work degrees. We also have a number of people who come from the community and relate to the cause in some way — perhaps connected through a relative or acquaintance.

About 60% of our funding comes from sources within the country. Among that 60%, a large number are individual, ordinary people. One of our steadiest supporters gives us 11 rupees every day, and has done so for the last 25 years. People who engage with us tend to stay engaged for a long time, whatever the amount — it all adds up. Around 40% comes from the Indian diaspora abroad, and we do have some long-term international donor partners who share our ideological position.

You should also know upfront that Prajwala has a fairly particular reputation among donors internationally — we're often seen as an "arrogant" organisation, because we are not project-funded; we are need-based, and everything about the organisation has evolved organically. It isn't that I decided in advance what would work and what wouldn't — it moved at an organic pace, because I founded the organisation and my own journey shaped it; that's written about at length in my memoir. We've been one of the few organisations to tell donors plainly: if you share our felt needs and our ideology, we'll take your money. We hold a very clear position — we are hardcore abolitionists, anti-prostitution and anti-slavery. There's a large lobby, in India and globally, that believes prostitution should be legalised, and we are completely opposed to that. So we don't take money from any organisation that has even a hint of ambiguity on that position — even neutrality is disqualifying, because a neutral funder is a dangerous group to be tied to. That narrows down considerably how many people we can take money from, but it also removes a layer of friction — we already have more than enough friction on the ground; we don't need more from the top.

Neharika Vohra: Managing 200 people isn't an easy task, and you seem to be the one conceiving, running and motivating people. What are your insights on getting the best out of the people you work with?

Sunitha Krishnan: One thing is that every team works entirely by example — what you are, how you lead, how you conduct yourself, is a critical part of everything you say. What you say, what you don't say, what's verbal and what isn't, and how you live your life, are all part of what your team sees. For me, this has worked in a big way because I am a full-time volunteer — I'm not tied to the organisation by a salary, which gives me a certain moral strength to speak and act as I believe is right, and to stand up for the right reasons.

The other part is keeping motivation alive, because our field involves everyday risk. This morning we removed seven people from a brothel — and if you think about it, for every seven people removed, there might be seventy people whose livelihoods depend on them. So I've made seventy enemies this morning, and they will come at us from every possible direction, because it's their revenue we've dismantled. There's no day without drama here, and no nine-to-five structure to hide behind — you have to be available and accessible at any time.

So within our working hours, what matters is building in things that keep not just motivation high, but also create a healing space. All our campuses are structurally built for that — you enter and feel a sense of calm. We hold regular activities that might look rudimentary — a puja one day, an iftar another, the Stations of the Cross on another. It might look like I'm performing secularism, but I'm not — I'm trying to create every possible outlet for people to let go, to ventilate, and to draw on whatever spiritual strength sustains them. We also have a monthly tradition day, not an annual one, where everyone cooks for everyone — with 200 people, that's no small thing. These are small activities woven into how the organisation runs, as a way of life, so everyone gets space to breathe and process what's happening.

I won't deny that despite all this, a certain desensitisation creeps in regardless. That's genuinely painful for me, because I've become a better professional over the last 35 years, but I've never let myself become desensitised — and that's a very thin line to walk.

Neharika Vohra: Also, with your school — you have learning centres as well. How does that work? Do you have trained teachers, are they part of the 200, or do you partner with schools?

Sunitha Krishnan: We can't afford trained teachers. As a grassroots organisation, given our funding, we have real limits on what we can offer with just these 200 people. Across the learning centres, the shelters, and all our ground programmes, we spend around 90 lakh rupees a month, and sustaining even that is a challenge. Because our salaries are modest, premier institutions like TISS don't come near us for recruitment — we simply can't match that pay scale. So we recruit people who've completed their 10th or 12th standard and train them ourselves as teachers, in partnership with professional trainers. IB schools have effectively adopted us and run residential training for our teachers every year. We also partner with organisations like Pratham for open-school learning. So a large part of the training comes through partnerships, but the actual execution is carried out by our own team.

Neharika Vohra: And with such modest salaries, do people tend to leave, or do they stay? What's your attrition like?

Sunitha Krishnan: It's ironic — around 20% of our staff leave after about two years, because once they've received basic training from us, there's a big demand for them in the market; anyone trained at Prajwala is in demand, and I know of institutions that hire "Prajwala products" without even interviewing them. But over time, a significant number stay on and become deeply engaged with the cause. None of them arrived that way, though — nobody came to me already wanting to fight trafficking. They came because either they liked my public image, or they needed a job — nothing more romantic than that. I'm yet to meet a single person who told me they joined because they specifically wanted to fight trafficking. But I've seen many of them develop a solid commitment to the cause over time and stay with us — some for more than 20 years. Interestingly, it's often not the professional staff but the teachers and community members we've engaged who become the real torchbearers; they bring a commitment that, once you've worked alongside them, is hard to walk away from, even when better-paying jobs are available elsewhere. Many have been with me for more than 25 years — for some, their working lives have essentially unfolded entirely within the organisation. But if you can't hold on to someone past the first two years, generally you lose them — there are always people who leave.

Neharika Vohra: So what you're also saying is that once people begin to identify with the cause, that's when they become truly committed, even if they weren't committed to it at the start.

Sunitha Krishnan: Yes, absolutely. I'd put it more precisely this way: they have to find an identity within the cause, and they have to be recognised and appreciated for it. You have to create space for the outside world to see them — if you remain the only face of the organisation, that's a losing proposition. In the public domain, people like you may only engage with me, because I'm the articulate, English-speaking face of the organisation. But if you go to the police stations across the country where my team works, I'm nobody there — they ask for Ali, they ask for Nazia, they ask for Srikanth; they've heard of some elusive "madam" somewhere, but they don't really know who she is. The same goes for the judges, and for our grassroots partners — most of them have no real idea who Sunitha Krishnan is. They've heard of this ghost-like figure, but the affirmation of identity goes to the people actually on the ground, and that's exactly the space that needs to be created. You can't be everywhere, and you can't take all the credit.

You have to build space for people to receive what's due to them. For me, that hasn't been some noble decision — it's been a practical one. There was a point on the ground when I needed to be front and centre, but a point also came when my visibility had to recede, largely for security reasons — I've been assaulted more than 17 times, and further exposure wasn't practical. So I had to push others forward. And once you push someone forward, you have to let them take the credit too — why would this person keep doing it without any gratification? So if the organisation wins an award, I push that person to receive it. These are practical decisions, nothing noble about them — I want to be clear that these are strategic responses.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you for sharing that — I think one of the most basic human needs is some form of visibility.

Sunitha Krishnan: Absolutely — especially when someone is doing the work and somebody else takes the credit, that's one of the most painful things. So I've been clear from the beginning: I'm the face for fundraising and for advocacy, and to that extent my visibility serves a purpose. But for everything else, my team has to be out front. It doesn't matter whether people like it or not — this is the leader who represents that piece of work, and I stand by that. That kind of decentralised structure, from top to bottom, now means that even a coordinator-level person engages directly with a Commissioner of Police. I recently met a commissioner who told me he'd already met my team and my "team leader," assuming that person was the head of the organisation. I told him, yes — for that piece of work, he is the head. But for the whole organisation, I'm still there. It's a difficult balance, wanting succession, wanting people to grow into leadership, while also not holding on to them as the only face who gives speeches or engages the media — but we try to maintain it.

Neharika Vohra: It would be lovely to have a couple of pictures of your team for the podcast as well. And on decision-making within the organisation — how does that happen?

Sunitha Krishnan: That's evolved organically too, over time. In the early years, I was everything for the organisation — I did the rescues, I was the first cook, the first teacher; I come from that fully grassroots space. For a very long time, I was the key decision-maker, and it took a while for me to negotiate, within myself, the ability to let go. When you've gone through life-threatening situations — attempts on your life and so on — you become extremely possessive, not of your position, but of the organisation's safety. You start to believe you know best because you've survived the worst, and that you won't make a mistake the organisation can't afford. I believed that for a long time, and in some ways still do, but it's taken real internal work to make space for others to make their own mistakes.

Decision-making is fundamentally about making mistakes and learning from them. Over the last 15 years, my job has been to help my team make their own mistakes while holding them steady as they learn — a genuinely tough journey, because even the team gets used to someone else making the call, someone else being accountable. Letting the responsibility actually land on them — when it may fall on them — was hard, especially because our decisions aren't business decisions; they affect life and death for real people. Things can go wrong, sometimes horribly wrong, particularly when you're dealing with organised crime — how much public exposure is needed, where to withdraw, when to speak to the media and when not to, where to act and where to hold back. These are all decisions that come only from experience, so for a long time I let my team accumulate that experience themselves.

Over the last 15 years, and especially the last four, the team has been reconstituted as a group that self-manages the organisation. We now have a Peer Review Committee that reviews each other's work, so what was once a single leader's decision has become a collective one, made by a team of leaders. The fear of everything falling on one person is gone — accountability is now shared. I wouldn't say we've reached the end of that process; it's still very much a work in progress.

Neharika Vohra: It's always a work in progress. That's a very difficult thing for leaders to learn — to let go.

Sunitha Krishnan: Yes, we're on the journey. Everything about Prajwala has been an organic journey, and four years ago, when I was diagnosed with cancer, that really accelerated the consolidation. Until you're in that space, you don't feel the push — things were moving at their own pace, and then this happened, and I had to take a step back. I was diagnosed with lung cancer, went into remission for three years, and then in April 2025 had a relapse — I'm now in the fourth stage of lung cancer. So I'm in a position where I genuinely have to think hard about where the organisation goes from here. Thankfully, because the process has been so organic — and I'd say, oddly, I'm even grateful to this health condition for it — the decentralisation of leadership and power has happened seamlessly. It's no longer a question of "how can we report to this other person while madam is still here" — now the instinct is, "we shouldn't trouble madam; it's our responsibility to let this leadership grow, because that's what will give her some rest."

You need to understand the kind of leader I've been — I come from a very strong, dominant drive. I'm the kind of person who takes up the entire space; there are people who wouldn't even come on stage with me because they assumed I would overshadow them completely. I've built up a larger-than-life persona over the years, and when you think about succession for someone like that, you're really talking about replacing one hero figure with another — which is difficult, especially while that person is still alive and active, because everyone measures the successor against "she wasn't the same way, she isn't doing what Sunitha did." But somehow, in this landscape, it has moved seamlessly. There's now a recognition that there is a legacy to carry forward — and that the legacy belongs to the organisation, not to me. Every piece of work we've done has been the team's work; I've simply been a co-traveller alongside them, and they've come to see it that way too. Thirty years of Prajwala has built something we need to carry forward the way it's been carried for the last three decades — and that transition has now happened seamlessly. I'm at a point where I feel comfortable; I'm not anxious about whether people will accept a different leader.

At the same time, I'm also very practical about this. Any founder carries a certain kind of "madness" that simply can't be replicated through succession planning. Most founders become founders because they have particular qualities — risk-taking ability, being multi-talented and multi-skilled, holding many things within one person. You're unlikely to find a single successor with all of those same qualities, because anyone who did have them would found their own organisation rather than take over someone else's — they have enough on their own to work independently. So what's left is people who individually may not carry every one of those qualities, and what works in an organisation like mine, given that, is collective leadership — a certain internal democracy among leaders, and an accountability framework at every level to sustain it. In this kind of work, every single link in the chain matters. I can give a powerful speech, but if my counsellor mishandles a case, I'm done. Forget the counsellor — if my security guard makes a mistake, I'm done. So everything I say has to travel, uniformly, all the way down to the last person in the organisation, and back up again in the same language and the same position — otherwise the organisation doesn't hold together. It can't be that I define therapy or healing one way, and someone else defines it differently further down. We're living out what we say, every single second — these aren't speeches we deliver once and move on from. And when survivors are your own colleagues and partners in the organisation, they become your conscience-keepers — they'll call you out the moment they feel you've drifted from the core path.

I've been fortunate that over the last 30-odd years, I've been able to build those checks and balances from the bottom up, so that even if I go wrong, there's someone to nudge me and say, this isn't right, we need to correct it. And again, we haven't reached the end of that process.

Neharika Vohra: I wish you a full recovery. This has been a huge learning for us as well. You mentioned that rescuing seven people might mean angering seventy, and that you work with communities who believe stealing others' children for prostitution

is acceptable, or the only way of life available to them. How do you engage with that with any equanimity? I know you can't simply disengage — but what helps you keep going?

Sunitha Krishnan: I'd answer that differently. There was a period when I actively engaged with those communities directly, and during that time we had to make far too many compromises to sustain that engagement — that was the early years of Prajwala, from 1996 to around 2005, the first ten years of the organisation. When we engaged actively with these communities, we were forced into our own compromises — we might rescue someone but not file a case, because I'd know exactly who was responsible, since they were part of that same community, but filing a case would turn the whole community against us. My very first staff member was a former pimp, and my biggest fear was always that he would be attacked or killed — and that did happen. One of my staff members was stabbed to death.

Those were the early adjustments and compromises we made, because you're working within a community you're simultaneously trying to disrupt — you can only push so far before you hit a wall. After about ten years — and I'd also call this my "God syndrome" phase — in the first few years you start to feel like a hero, because you're doing things nobody else has attempted, and doing them in ways nobody else has tried. You're putting your life on the line every minute — going in, pulling girls out, getting beaten up, going to hospital for surgery, coming out and doing another rescue the next day. It was an extraordinary high, and that high gets into your head — you start to believe you're the one everyone should look up to, a kind of moral high you begin to live inside.

It also brought a certain condescension toward the outside world — a sense of "what are you people even doing, sitting in your armchairs?" It took me a while to recognise how unsustainable that was. I don't regret how I lived through that period, because it's exactly how I came to understand what needed to change — I wouldn't have arrived at that understanding any other way. But I did have to lose a colleague before I got that real reality check, before I recognised this path wasn't sustainable and wasn't right. At the same time, I had to make a decision about what I actually wanted: did I simply want to keep rescuing individual girls, or did I want to dismantle the system itself? If the goal is to dismantle a community's exploitative structure entirely, you can't keep engaging with it — you can't be sharing a meal with someone in the daytime and working to bring them down at night. It doesn't work. So I made the call to create distance, and once we did, the relationship became openly antagonistic.

Today we've reached a point of clear antagonism — my presence in certain areas alone puts people on edge, wondering if something is about to happen. The boundaries are now very clearly drawn. But we didn't start there, and we didn't arrive at that position quickly. That said, I've always kept a window open for anyone who genuinely wants to engage with us. During Covid, when everything else came to a standstill, we were among the very few organisations still extending relief support to these communities — we were the ones providing groceries and essentials, and interestingly, they trusted only us, because we'd built a reputation as people who keep our word. So that window stays open — there are people who say, "I can't come out myself, but please look after my child," or "I can't come out, but I'll help you get someone else out." Those are the two kinds of relationships we still have with that world. Beyond that, as a matter of pragmatic strategy, we don't engage with them.

Neharika Vohra: That makes a lot of sense — you can't go to bed with your enemy.

Sunitha Krishnan: It's very difficult. And that's also why so many programmes run by the health ministry, including HIV/AIDS programmes, end up witnessing trafficking and exploitation happening right in front of them but staying silent, because speaking up would jeopardise their own project — and in staying silent, they end up endorsing it.

Neharika Vohra: Just a couple more questions, and it's been such a great conversation. You also have survivors who may be living with HIV or otherwise have limited options. Do you partner with doctors and medical specialists to provide relief and dignity to them?

Sunitha Krishnan: Absolutely. If you look at our list of partners, it isn't only in education — there are corporates and institutions partnering with us across many areas, and health is one of the largest. Irrespective of HIV status, health is one of the biggest forms of collateral damage for a survivor of sex trafficking — sexually transmitted infections, reproductive tract infections, and a very high incidence of traumatic brain injury; 78% of the women we work with have suffered some form of TBI. So health is a major area of focus for us. We partner with Apollo Hospitals, who provide full-time doctors and nurses, and we also work with psychiatrists and mental health institutions for psychiatric care. We've tied up with government hospitals for antiretroviral drugs for those who are HIV positive — many of our survivors who work with us are HIV positive and lead genuinely fulfilling lives; it's absolutely not the barrier people assume. You can live with HIV for decades today, given how far medical intervention has come, as long as you manage opportunistic infections and take your antiretroviral medication on schedule. Many of our survivors have been living with HIV for more than 20 years, without any real difficulty.

Neharika Vohra: I'd like to ask about how technology is enabling the demand for child sexual abuse material, and what young people — or any of us — can do, given that staying silent makes us complicit too.

Sunitha Krishnan: Absolutely, Neharika. We need to understand that the same technology we're using for this podcast has tremendous benefits, but also its own costs — the world has effectively become one shared platform for both good and bad actors, and a great many perpetrators are lurking on these platforms, using every trick available, with a much wider and largely borderless reach — whether it's Facebook, Instagram, Snapchat, or YouTube, the world is at your fingertips, and so is exposure to harm.

This is one of the great challenges of our time — how to make these platforms safer for women, girls, and especially children. Online gaming has become one of the biggest conduits for trapping young boys and children. We conducted a nationwide study on how technology enables human trafficking, including a decoy operation across various platforms to test how easily one could access child sexual abuse material, or CSAM. Beyond how easy that access turned out to be, one of the most disturbing findings was how many children are themselves being turned into perpetrators through technology. A child is trapped on an online gaming platform, runs up debts, exhausts whatever resources are available — sometimes even taking a family credit card to keep playing — and then has no way to pay it back. At that point, so-called "friends" on the platform will casually suggest making a video, taking a friend into a bathroom or behind a building, filming it, and uploading it in exchange for credit or points. More than 30% of the material accessed through these platforms consists of self-generated videos — children filming other children.

Neharika Vohra: That's the most frightening part.

Sunitha Krishnan: And that's the most frightening part of today's reality. We all have a tendency not to wake up to something until it touches us directly — much like how most of us were indifferent to the war in Ukraine, or events in Gaza, until suddenly a crisis affects something as immediate as your own household — and everyone starts paying attention. Until it hits you personally, you don't wake up. What I'd urge everyone watching this podcast to do is to wake up now, and to make online safety a real part of how they engage with their children and their families — to start practising digital detox. The screen time you carry through your day is genuinely one of the most hazardous things you're doing to yourself and your family, and what your child absorbs from your own example matters enormously. Even starting a digital detox in your own home is a meaningful contribution.

And since many of you are from IIM, and some of you will go on to lead companies — if you become the head of a technology company, please ensure that safeguarding protocols protecting the safety of women and children are built into your platforms. It may not always make obvious business sense, but it is genuinely good, ethical business, and I think that's a practice worth committing to.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you for that message. My last question is for the young people who might be watching this and considering entering a space like anti-trafficking or survivor support. What would you want to say to them — or to anyone considering a difficult field like this — and I hope they choose to.

Sunitha Krishnan: If you choose this, don't come here for tourism. This isn't a space for an internship experience that leaves you "sensitised" before you return to a comfortable, commercial life elsewhere. If you're coming, come prepared — it takes passion and drive, but it takes real skill too, from perseverance to resilience. You need to do real work on yourself, because this is a field with no easy results and no easy answers, and anti-trafficking work doesn't happen through speeches. A lot of well-educated people enter this space, organise a football match or give a talk or go on the TEDx circuit, and believe that's anti-trafficking work — it isn't. You need to get your hands dirty and actually engage with what's happening on the ground. And more than anything, you need to sustain that engagement — if you come for a single day and run the moment things get difficult, you won't see the change you set out for. Change is inevitable, but it takes time.

Believe in yourself, but you don't need to reinvent the wheel — there are many of us who've already done some of this work. If you're interested, read my memoir; it lays out my way of approaching things. There are others who've done similar work in their own way too — gain perspective from them, but you don't have to follow anyone else's path exactly. You have to carve out your own. Unlike when I started, 30 years ago, when there were very few precedents to draw on, today you at least have some lessons learned that you can use as a starting point. But do the research, prepare yourself, and equip yourself with the right skills before you enter.

It's a war. In a war, untrained people don't go in as soldiers — remember that. Equip yourself properly. If I've survived 35 years of this, you can too.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you so much. It's been so amazing to talk with you. I hope you continue this work, and I hope that at some point in our lives, we see a real reduction in this, if not a complete end to it.

Sunitha Krishnan: If somebody asks me what my vision for Prajwala is, my vision is a day when we can close it down — when there's no longer any need for an organisation like Prajwala. That's the day we're working toward.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you so much. I'll stop the recording now.

Sunitha Krishnan: Thank you. Thank you. Thank you.